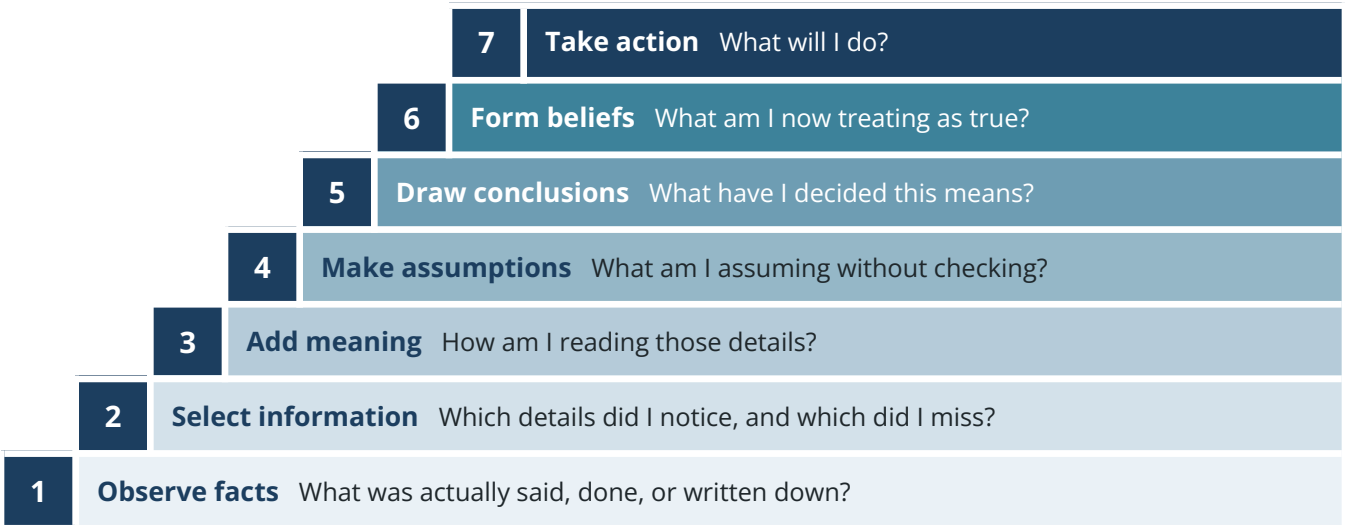
02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | RESOURCE

Understanding the Ladder of Inference

The seven steps from what we observe to what we do

The Ladder of Inference shows how we get from what we observe to how we act. We often climb it in seconds without noticing. Knowing the steps helps you see when an interpretation has turned into an assumption.



START HERE • Read from 1 at the bottom to 7 at the top.

The feedback loop

Our beliefs affect what we notice next. For example, if you believe a coworker never responds, you may notice every delay and miss the times they did reply. Look for information that does not fit your first explanation.

> **Use it to check your own thinking**
> The ladder is a tool for checking your own conclusions. It is not a way to label other people. Describe what you saw or heard, ask a neutral question, and listen for anything that could change your view. A conclusion can be reasonable and still need to be checked.

Source: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: TED-Ed lesson | USC explanation of the seven steps

02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | RESOURCE (CONTINUED)

Example: Checking an Assumption

This is a made-up workplace example, not a real County case.

Steps on the ladder	What might happen
1–2. Facts and what you notice	A supervisor replies, "Please send your recommendation." You notice the request, but you may not know what information the supervisor still needs.
3–4. Meaning and assumptions	You read the reply as a brush-off and assume the decision has already been made. The supervisor did not say either of these things.
5–7. Conclusion, belief, and action	You decide your input won't matter and that the process is pointless. You put off the request or send a frustrated reply.

A better next step

> **Ask a clarifying question**
> "I can prepare a recommendation. Which decision needs to be made, what facts should I include, and when do you need it?"

Then confirm your role. You may be responsible for the research and recommendation while someone else approves it. Share the facts you have checked, the open question, and the next step you recommend.

Try it with a current situation

Use this space	Your notes
What I observed	
My assumption, or another explanation	
Who to ask, and what	
What I will do next	

When your view changes

> *"At first I thought _____. After I checked _____, I learned _____. My next step is _____."*

Source: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."